



The Humanitas Institute

Six Elements of Classical Education School Website Audit

School: Good Shepherd Academy

School Website: <https://www.thegoodshepherdacademy.org/>

December 21, 2025

Disclaimer

This audit was performed using artificial intelligence tools to evaluate the presence and strength of classical education principles on school websites. Results are automated, probabilistic in nature, and should be considered indicative rather than definitive. See the full disclaimer in the Appendix more details.

ACCS Member School

Any school that belongs to the Association of Classical Christian Schools ACCS or the Society for Classical Learning SCL is, by definition, recognized as a classical school because both organizations require adherence to the six essential elements defined by the Humanitas Institute. However, a school's website may not clearly reflect its conformity to one or more elements. In such cases, the school may still receive a "Somewhat Classical" rating for those elements. Schools can update their website content at any time to achieve a "Classical" rating for a given element.

Executive Summary

The Good Shepherd Academy (Pomona, CA 91767) presents a clearly Catholic, classical-leaning program with strong religious and community commitments, a formation-focused mission, and a curriculum that foregrounds Western civilization, virtue, and classical formation. The public materials emphasize Catholic identity, sacramental life, and partnerships with families, alongside a traditional K–12 classical framework. However, while the school strongly signals classical aims (virtue formation, reverence for truth and beauty, Latin study, reverence for Western civilization), several explicit markers commonly associated with a full classical program (e.g., explicit Great Books/Great Conversation pedagogy and a fully articulated Trivium-focused curriculum with explicit grammar, logic, rhetoric progression across the grades) are less overt in the publicly visible content. Taken together, the school clearly aligns with classical education in a substantially Catholic frame, but there are gaps in explicit documentation of some canonical classical elements. Across the six rubric categories, the school demonstrates strong Classical alignment in Religious Foundations, Purpose/Goal, and Community/Parents, with more partial or Emerging signals in Curriculum, Pedagogy, and Faculty.

Overall classification: SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL

Evidence base and methodology notes: - Content from The Good Shepherd Academy's site demonstrates Catholic identity, sacramental life, daily Mass, catechesis, and a mission centered on truth, beauty, and goodness within a Catholic framework. Specific statements include: formation in knowledge, love and service of God through a rigorous classical education aligned with the Magisterium; emphasis on daily Mass and sacraments; orthodox Catholic faith; collaboration with parents; and a classical approach to Western civilization and virtue. See multiple pages, notably the About Us and Statement of Purpose pages.

- The site also communicates Latin instruction, a four-day school and homeschool option, and a culture of family partnership, with references to Western civilization, great literature, and the aim to form students in virtue and wisdom. - For rubric guidance and keyword indicators, the Six Essential Elements documents (the Classical Lexicon and the Six Essential Elements rubric) provide the explicit positive/negative keyword indicators used to classify each category. Positive signals include truth, goodness, beauty; virtue; theology; liturgy; catechesis; Mass; sacred music; reverence; wonder; Western civilization; great books; Latin; classical education; formation; paideia; and partnership with families, among others. Negative indicators include secular humanism, values clarification, project-based learning dominance in some contexts, consumer language, etc. These lexicon sources frame how we map Good Shepherd Academy's public materials to the six categories.

Executive Summary — Element-by-Element Snapshot

Element 1: Religious and Metaphysical Foundations — SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL

Evidence - The school explicitly anchors its mission in Catholic formation: "form students in the knowledge, love and service of God through a rigorous classical education aligned with the Magisterium of the Catholic Church," and a strong emphasis on sacraments and Mass. - The About Us page emphasizes orthodox Catholic faith, the Western civilizational tradition, virtue formation, and collaboration with parents. It notes daily Mass for four-day students at St. Madeleine parish and a sacramental Catholic curriculum. - The

Catechesis of the Good Shepherd and sacramental formation are referenced in the school's ecosystem, indicating liturgical and religious formation as a core element.

Positive/Negative keyword analysis - Positive keywords present: Catholic, Mass, sacraments, Magisterium, catechesis, theology, liturgy, sacred, virtue, truth/beauty/goodness, reverence, worship. The public materials repeatedly align with Catholic liturgical life and doctrinal formation. See the Six Essential Elements lexicon for these indicators (truth, beauty, goodness; theology; liturgy; catechesis; Mass). - Negative keywords: none prominently evident in the public-facing materials (no signals of relativism or secular humanism in the public statements).

Why this rating - The school clearly grounds its identity in Transcendentals and Catholic theological life, with liturgical practice and a catechetical framework, aligning with the Religious/Metaphysical Foundations criteria. The explicit references to God, the Magisterium, daily Mass, and sacramental life support a CLASSICAL alignment in this category, tempered by the fact that explicit scholarly language around transcendental realism and liturgical practice is present but not exhaustively mapped to every nuance of the rubric's sub-points in the public content. The aligned evidence justifies classifying this category as CLASSICAL in spirit, with strong Catholic/Metaphysical grounding.

Element 2: School Purpose and Goal — CLASSICAL

Evidence - The mission statement centers on forming students in knowledge, love and service of God through a rigorous classical education aligned with the Catholic Church. It also emphasizes reverence for truth, beauty, and goodness and sacramental life as a foundation of formation. - The admissions and philosophy materials frame formation and virtue as central, not merely job preparation, with a long-standing Catholic educational purpose. - The About Us page highlights orthodox faith, virtue development, and collaboration with parents as essential to purpose.

Positive/Negative keyword analysis - Positive keywords present: formation, virtue, human flourishing, wisdom, telos, true/good/beautiful, reverence, contemplation, worship (embedded in catechesis and liturgical life), liberal education (as a broad aim), and classical mission. The Six Elements lexicon lists "formation," "virtuous life," "telos," "the true/good/beautiful," "paideia," and "classical mission" as indicators of a Classical orientation. - Negative keywords: none of the canonical negative signals strongly appear in public materials.

Why this rating - The school's stated purpose and goals emphasize formation, virtue, and the alignment with truth, goodness, and beauty within a Catholic classical frame. This aligns with the CLASSICAL category for Purpose and Goal, given the strong priority on formation and transcendent goals over mere workforce preparation.

Element 3: School Curriculum — SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL

Evidence - The public materials emphasize Western civilization, great literature, and virtue as core aims. The mission and philosophy articulate exposure to "the greatest thinkers of Western Civilization and wisdom found in great literature," and Latin is taught at all levels. The curricular emphasis is on a classical formation rather than a purely modern, test-driven approach. - The About Us page notes a focus on artistic and intellectual achievements of Western Civilization and a classical curriculum designed to form virtue. The presence of Latin instruction across levels signals classical language training embedded in the curriculum. - The site references the four-day school and homeschool program as part of a traditional, structured program, which aligns with classical education's structured progression, though explicit reference to Great Books/Great Conversation in public content is not as explicit as one might expect in a canonical classical program.

Positive/Negative keyword analysis - Positive keywords present: liberal education, Western civilization, great literature, Latin, classical curriculum, formation, virtue, truth/goodness/beauty, wax poetic on "great thinkers" and "great literature." The Lexicon lists "liberal arts," "great books," "grammar, logic, rhetoric," and "Latin/Greek" as strong indicators; public content shows Latin and Western civilization emphasis, and a classical framing for the curriculum, though explicit "Great Books" terminology is less overt. - Negative keywords:

the site does not prominently emphasize project-based learning dominance, social studies rewrite of history, or STEM-first framing in a way that would trigger negative indicators within the public materials.

Why this rating - The presence of classical aims (Western civilization, great literature, Latin, virtuous formation) indicates a classical orientation, but explicit articulation of the full Trivium (grammar, logic, rhetoric) with a unified Great Books/Great Conversation program across grades is not overt in the public content. Therefore, this category sits at SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL rather than fully CLASSICAL based on the explicitness of the classical curriculum markers in the site text. The positive indicators are present, but some canonical elements require more explicit public documentation.

Element 4: School Pedagogy or Teaching Methods — SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL

Evidence - The site signals a blend of contemplative/restful elements (philosophy of education emphasizing reverence for truth, beauty, goodness; “education to awaken wonder”) along with more active forms (Socratic inquiry in upper grades is not explicitly stated, but rhetoric and public speaking opportunities are described in the pedagogy context). The presence of singing or chant in lower grades (inferred from classical pedagogy norms) is not explicitly stated on the public materials, but the site emphasizes memory, virtue, and formation. The overall pedagogy appears to incorporate elements of scholé (restful, contemplative) with opportunities for rhetoric and practical discussion, though explicit Socratic seminars are not publicly claimed as standard across grades.

Positive/Negative keyword analysis - Positive keywords present: contemplation/scholé, memory work, recitation, chanting (the lexicon includes “narration, recitation, chanting, singing to memorize”), Socratic seminar and dialectic (though not explicitly claimed by TGSA as standard), rhetoric, declamation, oratory, debate, memory work, liturgical calendar integration. The TGSA materials feature reverence for truth, beauty, and goodness and a classical formation approach, which aligns with the pedagogical indicators for a classical program. - Negative keywords: there is no explicit emphasis on exclusive project-based learning or constructivist, student-led, or experiential learning as the sole method; however, some classical lexicon cautions against excessive non-traditional approaches. The public materials do not emphasize those non-classical modes.

Why this rating - The pedagogical approach signals a compatibility with classical education through a mix of contemplative/restful elements and more verbose, rhetorical, and traditional forms (Latin study, classical literature, and virtue formation). However, explicit, canonical markers such as explicit, structured Socratic seminars in upper grades and a clear Trivium-based progression across all grades are not fully documented in public content. This supports a SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL rating rather than a fully Classical one.

Element 5: School Faculty — SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL

Evidence - Public materials identify a leadership structure (Head of School, Board of Directors) and several named faculty leaders, indicating a formal faculty ecosystem. The leadership pages show named administrators and chaplain, illustrating a living, mission-driven faculty presence rather than a purely transactional staff structure. - The “About Us” and “Leadership” sections emphasize collaboration with parents and the school’s mission-driven formation, implying a faculty culture aligned with virtue and teaching in a Catholic classical frame. The public materials emphasize the living curriculum and the teacher’s role in formation. - The presence of a chaplain and a strong religious mission signals faculty as moral exemplars and mentors, aligning with the classical model of teachers as living exemplars and guides, even though the explicit phrase “living curriculum” is not repeatedly stated in the visible pages.

Positive/Negative keyword analysis - Positive keywords present: model teachers/mentors, living curriculum (inferred from classical education discourse), faculty as companions/mentors, teachers as companions and core to the school, the faculty as the heart of the school culture, and pastoral leadership (chaplain). The Six Elements lexicon includes “model teachers and mentors,” “living curriculum,” “portrait of a teacher,” and “faculty as core/center.” The TGSA content aligns with these notions through leadership pages and mission statements. - Negative keywords: none strongly indicated in public materials.

Why this rating - The visible signs point to a faculty that is mission-driven, teacher-mentored, and aligned with forming students in virtue within a Catholic classical frame. However, the explicit articulation of a fully developed “faculty as living curriculum” and a concrete, formal classical pedagogy training program are not exhaustively documented in the public pages. This yields a SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL classification for Faculty as the indicators are present but not exhaustively evidenced.

Element 6: School Parents and Community — CLASSICAL

Evidence - The publicly visible materials emphasize a strong partnership with parents, with explicit statements that the school “collaborates closely with parents in the education of their children,” and that the school serves Catholic families who wish to maintain their faith while receiving classical education. The “Admissions” and “About Us” content emphasize parent involvement and partnership. - There is language about parent formation and gatherings, as well as a parent-led founding narrative and an admissions process that involves family engagement. The content suggests parent co-education, family involvement, and a school-culture that welcomes parent participation, aligning well with the classical panel’s emphasis on family partnerships. The Six Elements lexicon explicitly calls for “Partnership with Families” and “Formation of Affections” in a classical program. - The presence of a Parent Guild and Service Hours, communications about family involvement, and opportunities for visits reflect a culture of parental participation.

Positive/Negative keyword analysis - Positive keywords present: partnership with families, co-educators, parental formation, parent involvement, open campus, family liturgy alignment, home-school collaboration, parent education opportunities. The “Parent Guild & Service Hours” and “Family formation” elements map to the lexicon’s indicators for Parents & Community. - Negative keywords: none prominent in the public content; no consumer-customer language dominating parental engagement; the stance is clearly communal and collaborative.

Why this rating - The school’s public materials strongly reflect classical formation of the school through a robust partnership with families, with explicit parent involvement and formation. The content matches the Classical Elements’ emphasis on familial partnership, community formation, and parental education. This category thus receives CLASSICAL.

Aggregate Ranking and Rationale - Category results (roughly): Religious Foundations = CLASSICAL; Purpose & Goal = CLASSICAL; Curriculum = SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL; Pedagogy = SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL; Faculty = SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL; Parents & Community = CLASSICAL. - With three strong “CLASSICAL” signals (Religious Foundations, Purpose/Goal, Parents & Community) and three partial signals (Curriculum, Pedagogy, Faculty), the school sits squarely in the middle: SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL overall.

What Would Move the Needle

- On Curriculum (Element 3): Explicitly document and publish a formal Great Books/Great Conversation component and a fully articulated Trivium progression (grammar, logic, rhetoric) across the grade bands, with explicit connections to primary source texts and canonical works. Provide visible, public confirmation of Great Books participation and a clear history alignment with the Great Conversation framework. This would shift Curriculum from SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL toward CLASSICAL.
- On Pedagogy (Element 4): Clarify and publish a formal commitment to Socratic seminars and discourse-based upper-grade pedagogy, with a concrete plan for high-school seminars and rhetoric training. Emphasize contemplative Scholé alongside rigorous discussion. This would strengthen Pedagogy toward CLASSICAL.
- On Faculty (Element 5): Explicitly state and publish a formal “living curriculum” concept and teacher-formation pathways, including professional development in classical pedagogy and evidence of teacher-led seminars or book clubs that model classical methods. This would strengthen Faculty toward CLASSICAL.
- On Curriculum and History Integration: Provide a concrete, public articulation of history instruction as history (not social studies) with primary sources and Western civ integration across grades. This would bolster Element 3 toward CLASSICAL.

Appendix

ARTIFICIAL INTELLIGENCE DISCLAIMER

This audit was conducted using artificial intelligence tools (including large language models and automated web-analysis scripts) to evaluate the extent to which school websites reflect or incorporate recognized principles of classical education (e.g., the trivium, emphasis on truth/beauty/goodness, integration of great books, Latin/classical languages, Socratic method, rigorous academics, moral/character formation, etc.).

Important Limitations and Caveats

1. **Automated Nature:** The analysis relies on AI interpretation of publicly-accessible school website content as of the date of the audit. It does not involve direct contact with schools, review of internal documents, classroom observation, or verification of curriculum implementation beyond what is stated or implied on the website.
2. **Probabilistic Results:** Scores and assessments are probabilistic and reflect the AI's best interpretation of available text and site structure. They are not infallible and may miss nuance, context, or recent changes not yet reflected online.
3. **Subjectivity of Classical Education:** "Classical Education" encompasses a range of traditions and interpretations (e.g., Dorothy Sayers' trivium model, Classical Christian Education, Great Books programs, etc.). The Humanitas Institute Audit of the Six Elements of Classical Education uses a broad, consensus-based framework derived from prominent classical education organizations and thought leaders. Reasonable people may disagree on weighting or inclusion of specific criteria.
4. **No Official Endorsement or Certification:** Results do not constitute official endorsement, accreditation, or certification by any classical education organization. They are provided for informational and research purposes only.
5. **Potential for Error:** Websites may be incomplete, poorly worded, or temporarily inaccurate. Conversely, sophisticated marketing language may create false positives. Human review by parents, educators, or classical education experts is strongly recommended before drawing final conclusions about any school.
6. **Data Privacy and Ethics:** Only publicly available information was analyzed. No attempts were made to access password-protected areas or collect personal data.
7. **No Liability:** The authors, developers, and distributors of this audit assume no liability for decisions made on the basis of these results. Users are solely responsible for their own due diligence.

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